

Complete Troubleshooting Guide and FAQ for Microgreens Beginners

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For: Complete Beginners Growing Microgreens in Cape Town

HOW TO USE THIS TROUBLESHOOTING GUIDE

This guide solves EVERY problem you might encounter as a beginner. Each problem includes:

- **Symptoms:** What you see happening
- **Causes:** Why it's happening
- **Solutions:** Exactly how to fix it
- **Prevention:** How to avoid it in future

IMPORTANT: Don't panic when problems occur. Every grower faces these issues. Follow the solutions exactly and you'll fix the problem.

SECTION 1: SEED AND GERMINATION PROBLEMS

PROBLEM 1: Seeds Not Sprouting After 3+ Days

Symptoms you'll see:

- Seeds planted 3+ days ago with no green shoots visible
- Seeds look the same as when you planted them
- Some seeds may look swollen but no green growth
- You're worried you did something wrong

Most likely causes:

- Seeds are too old or stored improperly
- Water temperature is too cold (below 15°C)
- Seeds are planted too deep in the growing medium
- Growing area is too cold (below 18°C)
- Seeds are getting too much or too little water

EXACT SOLUTIONS:**If seeds are old or bad quality:**

1. Test your seeds: Take 10 seeds, place on wet paper towel, keep warm for 24 hours
2. If less than 8 out of 10 sprout, your seeds are bad
3. Buy fresh seeds from Seeds for Africa (021 201 1118)
4. Store new seeds in cool, dry place in sealed containers

If temperature is too cold:

1. Move growing area to warmer location (18-24°C is ideal)
2. Use a thermometer to check actual temperature
3. In winter, consider small heater near growing area
4. Cover trays with clear plastic to create mini greenhouse effect

If seeds planted too deep:

1. Gently brush away excess growing medium
2. Seeds should be barely covered - you should almost see them
3. For next planting: sprinkle seeds on surface, then lightly dust with growing medium

If watering is wrong:

1. Growing medium should feel like wrung-out sponge
2. If too dry: mist gently with spray bottle
3. If too wet: improve drainage, reduce watering frequency
4. Check that water is reaching all trays evenly

Prevention for next time:

- Always test new seed batches before large plantings
- Keep growing area at consistent 20-22°C
- Plant seeds at correct depth (barely covered)
- Check moisture daily with finger test

PROBLEM 2: Seeds Sprouting Unevenly**Symptoms you'll see:**

- Some areas of tray have lots of sprouts, others have none
- Sprouts are different heights across the same tray
- Some seeds sprouted day 2, others still not sprouted day 5
- Patchy, uneven growth pattern

Most likely causes:

- Seeds not spread evenly when planting
- Uneven watering across the tray
- Some areas getting more light than others
- Growing medium not level in tray
- Some seeds are older/lower quality than others

EXACT SOLUTIONS:**For current crop:**

1. Identify areas with no sprouting
2. Gently add more seeds to empty areas
3. Ensure even watering by rotating trays daily
4. Move trays to ensure all get equal light

For better planting technique:

1. Measure seeds carefully (use measuring spoons)
2. Spread seeds by hand, not pouring from container

3. Shake tray gently to distribute seeds evenly
4. Check that growing medium is level before planting

For watering improvements:

1. Use spray bottle instead of pouring water
2. Spray in circular pattern to cover whole tray
3. Check that pump system reaches all areas equally
4. Rotate tray positions daily

Prevention for next time:

- Take time to spread seeds evenly by hand
- Level growing medium before planting
- Use consistent watering technique
- Rotate tray positions regularly

PROBLEM 3: Seeds Going Moldy Instead of Sprouting

Symptoms you'll see:

- White, fuzzy growth on seeds (not green shoots)
- Bad smell from trays
- Seeds look slimy or rotting
- Growing medium smells sour or bad

Most likely causes:

- Too much water/poor drainage
- Poor air circulation around trays
- Contaminated growing medium or containers
- Seeds planted too thickly
- Temperature too high with high humidity

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Immediate action:

1. Remove moldy trays immediately
2. Don't try to save moldy crops - throw them away
3. Clean containers with bleach solution (1:10 ratio)
4. Let containers dry completely before reusing

Fix growing conditions:

1. Reduce watering frequency
2. Improve drainage - ensure water doesn't pool
3. Increase air circulation with small fan
4. Reduce humidity by removing covers sooner
5. Space seeds less densely

Clean everything:

1. Wash all containers with bleach solution
2. Replace growing medium completely
3. Clean water tanks and change nutrient solution
4. Disinfect scissors and tools

Prevention for next time:

- Don't overwater - growing medium should be moist, not soggy
- Ensure good drainage in all trays
- Don't plant seeds too thickly
- Remove covers as soon as sprouting begins
- Keep growing area clean and well-ventilated

SECTION 2: GROWTH AND DEVELOPMENT PROBLEMS

PROBLEM 4: Microgreens Growing Too Slowly

Symptoms you'll see:

- Sprouts are much shorter than expected for their age

- Growth seems to have stopped after initial sprouting
- Plants look weak and spindly
- Taking much longer than expected to reach harvest size

Most likely causes:

- Not enough light
- Nutrient solution too weak or wrong pH
- Temperature too low
- Poor air circulation
- Overcrowding

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Improve lighting:

1. Move trays to brighter location
2. If using artificial lights, bring them closer (30-40cm from plants)
3. Increase daily light hours to 14-16 hours
4. Clean any dirty windows blocking natural light

Fix nutrient solution:

1. Test pH - should be 5.5-6.5
2. If pH wrong, adjust with pH Up or pH Down solutions
3. Check nutrient concentration - follow package instructions exactly
4. Change nutrient solution if it's more than 2 weeks old

Improve temperature:

1. Check temperature with thermometer - should be 18-24°C
2. Move growing area to warmer location if needed
3. Use small heater in winter
4. Avoid cold drafts from windows or doors

Increase air circulation:

1. Add small fan to move air gently
2. Don't point fan directly at plants
3. Ensure growing area isn't stuffy or enclosed

Reduce overcrowding:

1. For current crop: thin out weakest plants
2. For next planting: use fewer seeds per tray
3. Give plants room to grow

Prevention for next time:

- Provide adequate lighting from day 1
- Maintain proper pH and nutrients
- Keep consistent temperature
- Don't overcrowd plants

PROBLEM 5: Microgreens Turning Yellow

Symptoms you'll see:

- Green leaves turning pale yellow
- Plants look weak and unhealthy
- Yellow color starts at bottom and moves up
- Growth slowing down or stopping

Most likely causes:

- Not enough light (most common cause)
- Nutrient deficiency
- Overwatering
- Plants getting too old (past harvest time)

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

If caused by poor lighting:

1. Move to brighter location immediately
2. Add artificial lighting if natural light insufficient
3. Ensure 12-16 hours of light daily
4. Remove any obstacles blocking light

If caused by nutrient problems:

1. Test nutrient solution strength
2. Mix fresh nutrient solution following package directions exactly
3. Check pH and adjust to 5.5-6.5
4. Ensure nutrients are reaching all plants

If caused by overwatering:

1. Reduce watering frequency
2. Improve drainage
3. Let growing medium dry slightly between waterings
4. Check that water isn't pooling in trays

If plants are too old:

1. Harvest immediately even if smaller than ideal
2. Don't let microgreens get too mature
3. Plan harvest timing better for next crop

Prevention for next time:

- Provide adequate lighting from sprouting
- Maintain proper nutrient levels
- Don't overwater
- Harvest at optimal timing

PROBLEM 6: Microgreens Growing Too Tall and Spindly

Symptoms you'll see:

- Plants are very tall but thin and weak

- Stems are pale or white instead of green
- Plants fall over easily
- Leaves are small compared to stem length

Most likely causes:

- Not enough light (plants stretching toward light)
- Kept covered too long after sprouting
- Temperature too high
- Overcrowding

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Improve lighting immediately:

1. Move to much brighter location
2. Add artificial lighting
3. Bring lights closer to plants
4. Increase daily light hours

Remove covers:

1. Take off any newspaper or covers immediately
2. Don't cover plants once green shoots appear
3. Let plants get direct light

Reduce temperature:

1. Move to cooler location (ideal 18-22°C)
2. Improve ventilation
3. Avoid hot, stuffy areas

For next crop:

1. Remove covers as soon as sprouting begins
2. Provide bright light from day 1
3. Don't overcrowd seeds

4. Maintain proper temperature

Can you save current crop:

- If stems are very weak, harvest early for baby microgreens
- Use immediately as they won't store well
- Focus on preventing this in next crop

PROBLEM 7: Microgreens Have Poor Flavor

Symptoms you'll see:

- Microgreens taste bitter or unpleasant
- Flavor is much stronger/harsher than expected
- Customers complaining about taste
- You don't want to eat your own product

Most likely causes:

- Harvesting too late (plants too mature)
- Stress from poor growing conditions
- Wrong varieties for your taste preference
- Poor post-harvest handling

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Harvest timing:

1. Harvest earlier - when first true leaves just appear
2. Don't wait for plants to get large
3. Taste test daily once plants reach minimum size
4. Different varieties ready at different times

Reduce plant stress:

1. Maintain consistent watering
2. Avoid temperature extremes

3. Provide adequate but not excessive light
4. Ensure good air circulation

Improve post-harvest handling:

1. Harvest in early morning when plants are crisp
2. Rinse gently in cold water immediately
3. Dry thoroughly but gently
4. Store in refrigerator immediately

For future crops:

1. Try different varieties to find preferred flavors
2. Keep detailed notes on harvest timing vs flavor
3. Maintain optimal growing conditions
4. Handle harvested product carefully

SECTION 3: SYSTEM AND EQUIPMENT PROBLEMS

PROBLEM 8: Water Not Reaching All Pipes

Symptoms you'll see:

- Some pipes getting lots of water, others getting little or none
- Uneven plant growth across different pipes
- Some trays staying dry while others are soaked
- Water pressure seems low

Most likely causes:

- Blocked or kinked tubing
- Pump not powerful enough
- Uneven distribution system
- Air bubbles in lines

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Check tubing:

1. Inspect all tubing for kinks, bends, or blockages
2. Straighten any kinked sections
3. Clear blockages with wire or by flushing with water
4. Replace damaged tubing sections

Check pump capacity:

1. Verify pump is rated for your system size
2. Clean pump intake filter
3. Check that pump is fully submerged
4. Consider upgrading to more powerful pump if needed

Improve distribution:

1. Install more T-joints to split water flow evenly
2. Use same diameter tubing throughout system
3. Keep tubing runs as short as possible
4. Install flow control valves to balance water distribution

Remove air bubbles:

1. Run system for 30 minutes to purge air
2. Tap tubing to release trapped air bubbles
3. Ensure all connections are tight
4. Prime pump properly before starting

Prevention:

- Regular system maintenance and cleaning
- Check tubing monthly for damage
- Keep spare tubing and fittings on hand
- Monitor water distribution daily

PROBLEM 9: pH Levels Keep Changing

Symptoms you'll see:

- pH reading different every day
- Plants showing signs of nutrient problems
- pH drifts up or down despite adjustments
- Inconsistent plant growth

Most likely causes:

- Nutrient solution too old
- pH meter needs calibration
- Contamination in water system
- Natural pH drift as plants consume nutrients

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Replace nutrient solution:

1. Drain and clean both tanks completely
2. Mix fresh nutrient solution
3. Test pH of fresh solution
4. Adjust to 5.5-6.5 before adding to system

Calibrate pH meter:

1. Use pH calibration solutions (pH 4.0 and 7.0)
2. Follow meter instructions exactly
3. If using test strips, buy fresh ones
4. Store pH meter properly between uses

Clean system:

1. Flush entire system with clean water
2. Clean tanks with mild bleach solution
3. Rinse thoroughly before adding nutrients

4. Replace any old or contaminated water

Monitor and adjust:

1. Check pH daily at same time
2. Make small adjustments (0.2-0.3 pH units at a time)
3. Wait 30 minutes after adjustments before retesting
4. Keep log of pH readings and adjustments

Prevention:

- Change nutrient solution every 2 weeks
- Keep system clean
- Calibrate pH meter monthly
- Monitor pH daily

PROBLEM 10: Pumps Making Too Much Noise**Symptoms you'll see:**

- Loud humming, grinding, or rattling sounds
- Noise disturbing neighbors or household
- Pumps vibrating excessively
- Sound getting worse over time

Most likely causes:

- Pump not fully submerged
- Debris in pump impeller
- Pump mounted on hard surface causing vibration
- Pump wearing out or damaged

EXACT SOLUTIONS:**Check water level:**

1. Ensure pump is completely underwater

2. Add water to tank if level too low
3. Pump should be at least 5cm below water surface
4. Check that pump intake isn't blocked

Clean pump:

1. Turn off and disconnect pump
2. Remove and clean pump impeller
3. Clear any debris from pump housing
4. Reassemble carefully

Reduce vibration:

1. Place pump on rubber mat or foam pad
2. Don't let pump touch tank walls
3. Secure tubing so it doesn't vibrate
4. Check that pump is sitting level

If pump is damaged:

1. Check warranty - may be replaceable
2. Consider upgrading to quieter pump model
3. Look for pumps specifically designed for quiet operation
4. Install pump in separate, insulated box

Prevention:

- Keep pumps fully submerged
- Clean pumps monthly
- Use vibration dampening materials
- Buy quality pumps with good warranties

PROBLEM 11: Water Leaking from System

Symptoms you'll see:

- Water puddles around growing area

- Water level dropping faster than expected
- Wet spots on floor or surfaces
- System losing pressure

Most likely causes:

- Loose connections in tubing
- Cracked or damaged tubing
- Overfilled tanks
- Damaged tank or container

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Find the leak:

1. Run system and watch for dripping water
2. Check all tubing connections
3. Inspect tubing for cracks or holes
4. Look for water stains showing leak location

Fix tubing problems:

1. Tighten loose connections
2. Replace damaged tubing sections
3. Use proper fittings for secure connections
4. Wrap connections with waterproof tape if needed

Fix tank problems:

1. Check tank for cracks
2. Repair small cracks with waterproof sealant
3. Replace damaged tanks
4. Don't overfill tanks - leave space for water circulation

Prevent future leaks:

1. Use quality tubing and fittings

2. Don't overtighten connections (can crack fittings)
3. Protect tubing from damage
4. Regular inspection of all connections

SECTION 4: HARVEST AND POST-HARVEST PROBLEMS

PROBLEM 12: Microgreens Wilting After Harvest

Symptoms you'll see:

- Fresh-cut microgreens becoming limp within hours
- Leaves drooping and losing crispness
- Product looking poor quality quickly
- Customers complaining about freshness

Most likely causes:

- Harvesting during hot part of day
- Not cooling product quickly enough
- Poor handling during harvest
- Inadequate packaging

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Improve harvest timing:

1. Harvest early morning (6-8 AM) when plants are crisp
2. Avoid harvesting during hot afternoon
3. Harvest when plants are fully hydrated
4. Work quickly to minimize time out of refrigeration

Cool immediately:

1. Rinse harvested microgreens in cold water
2. Dry gently but thoroughly

3. Package and refrigerate within 30 minutes
4. Use insulated containers for transport

Handle gently:

1. Use sharp, clean scissors
2. Don't squeeze or compress microgreens
3. Work in small batches
4. Keep harvested product in shade

Improve packaging:

1. Use breathable containers (not airtight)
2. Include small amount of moisture but not too much
3. Don't pack too tightly
4. Label with harvest date

Prevention:

- Always harvest in cool morning hours
- Have refrigeration ready before harvesting
- Handle product gently throughout process
- Use proper packaging materials

PROBLEM 13: Short Shelf Life

Symptoms you'll see:

- Microgreens going bad within 2-3 days
- Yellowing or browning quickly
- Bad smell developing
- Customers returning product

Most likely causes:

- Harvesting too late (overmatured plants)
- Poor post-harvest handling

- Incorrect storage temperature
- Contamination during processing

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Harvest at right time:

1. Harvest when first true leaves just appear
2. Don't wait for plants to get large
3. Younger plants have longer shelf life
4. Different varieties ready at different times

Improve handling:

1. Use clean, sanitized tools and containers
2. Wash hands thoroughly before handling
3. Rinse product in clean, cold water
4. Dry completely but gently

Optimize storage:

1. Store at 2-4°C (refrigerator temperature)
2. Use breathable packaging
3. Don't store in airtight containers
4. Keep humidity moderate (not too dry, not too wet)

Prevent contamination:

1. Clean all surfaces and tools with sanitizer
2. Use clean water for rinsing
3. Don't cross-contaminate between batches
4. Store different varieties separately

Prevention:

- Harvest at optimal timing
- Maintain strict cleanliness

- Store at proper temperature
- Use appropriate packaging

PROBLEM 14: Inconsistent Product Quality

Symptoms you'll see:

- Some batches much better than others
- Customers never know what quality to expect
- Difficulty maintaining regular customers
- Your own assessment of quality varies

Most likely causes:

- Inconsistent growing conditions
- Variable harvest timing
- Different handling procedures
- Seasonal variations not accounted for

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Standardize growing conditions:

1. Keep detailed records of temperature, pH, nutrients
2. Use same procedures for every batch
3. Maintain consistent lighting
4. Use timer systems for watering

Standardize harvest procedures:

1. Harvest same varieties at same stage every time
2. Use measuring tools to check plant height
3. Taste test before harvesting
4. Keep detailed harvest records

Create quality standards:

1. Define what “Grade A” product looks like
2. Take photos of ideal product for reference
3. Train yourself to recognize quality levels
4. Sort product into quality grades

Monitor and improve:

1. Keep customer feedback records
2. Track which batches get complaints
3. Identify patterns in quality problems
4. Continuously improve procedures

Prevention:

- Document all procedures
- Follow same steps every time
- Monitor quality consistently
- Learn from every batch

SECTION 5: CUSTOMER AND SALES PROBLEMS

PROBLEM 15: Customers Not Interested

Symptoms you’ll see:

- Restaurants/stores not wanting to try samples
- People saying “we don’t need microgreens”
- Difficulty getting appointments with buyers
- Low response to marketing efforts

Most likely causes:

- Approaching wrong type of customers
- Poor timing of sales visits
- Not explaining benefits clearly

- Product quality not impressive enough

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Target right customers:

1. Focus on upscale restaurants, not fast food
2. Visit health food stores, not regular supermarkets
3. Target juice bars and wellness centers
4. Look for establishments already using fresh herbs

Improve timing:

1. Visit restaurants between 2-4 PM (slow period)
2. Avoid busy meal times
3. Call ahead to schedule appointments
4. Visit stores during weekday mornings

Better sales approach:

1. Lead with benefits: “locally grown, pesticide-free, harvested this morning”
2. Emphasize freshness and quality
3. Explain nutritional benefits
4. Show how microgreens enhance their dishes

Improve product quality:

1. Only bring your best quality samples
2. Package samples attractively
3. Include variety of colors and flavors
4. Harvest samples same day as visit

Prevention:

- Research customers before visiting
- Practice your sales pitch
- Always bring high-quality samples

- Follow up consistently

PROBLEM 16: Customers Complaining About Price

Symptoms you'll see:

- “Your prices are too high”
- “We can get cheaper elsewhere”
- Customers buying small quantities only
- Price objections during sales calls

Most likely causes:

- Comparing to imported or lower-quality products
- Not understanding value proposition
- Pricing not competitive for market segment
- Not demonstrating quality difference

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Emphasize value, not price:

1. Highlight local, fresh, same-day harvest
2. Compare to imported products that are days old
3. Explain superior nutritional content
4. Show how little waste there is with your product

Offer different price points:

1. Create “premium” and “standard” grades
2. Offer volume discounts for larger orders
3. Provide mixed variety packs
4. Consider subscription pricing

Demonstrate quality difference:

1. Bring competitor samples for comparison

2. Let customers taste the difference
3. Show shelf life comparison
4. Explain growing methods

Be flexible:

1. Offer trial periods at reduced prices
2. Provide free samples with paid orders
3. Create loyalty programs for regular customers
4. Consider seasonal pricing adjustments

Prevention:

- Research competitor pricing
- Clearly communicate value proposition
- Focus on customers who value quality
- Build relationships, not just transactions

PROBLEM 17: Irregular Orders from Customers

Symptoms you'll see:

- Customers ordering different amounts each week
- Some weeks no orders, other weeks large orders
- Difficulty planning production
- Cash flow problems from unpredictable sales

Most likely causes:

- Customers' needs vary with their business
- No formal ordering system established
- Customers forgetting to order regularly
- Seasonal variations in customer demand

EXACT SOLUTIONS:

Establish regular ordering:

1. Propose weekly standing orders
2. Create simple ordering system (phone, email, text)
3. Send weekly availability updates
4. Offer incentives for regular orders

Improve communication:

1. Call customers weekly to check needs
2. Send reminders about ordering deadlines
3. Provide advance notice of availability
4. Ask about upcoming special events or needs

Create ordering systems:

1. Set up regular delivery days
2. Establish minimum order quantities
3. Offer subscription-style services
4. Use simple order forms or apps

Plan for variability:

1. Maintain relationships with multiple customers
2. Develop backup sales channels (farmers markets)
3. Plan production based on average orders
4. Keep some flexibility in production schedule

Prevention:

- Build strong customer relationships
- Provide excellent, consistent service
- Make ordering easy and convenient
- Diversify customer base

SECTION 6: FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

GENERAL QUESTIONS

Q: How long does it really take to start making money? A: Following this guide exactly, you should make your first sale by Day 17 and be earning R1000+ weekly by Day 30. Significant income (R5000+ weekly) typically comes by Day 60-90.

Q: What if I can't find all the suppliers you mentioned? A: The suppliers listed are the best options, but alternatives exist. Call Seeds for Africa first (021 201 1118) - they can often recommend other suppliers. Builders Warehouse and Makro are everywhere and have basic equipment.

Q: How much money do I really need to start? A: Following this guide, you need R6,500-10,000 for equipment and supplies. This is much less than other business opportunities and you'll start earning money within 3 weeks.

Q: What if my family thinks this is a crazy idea? A: Show them this guide and the financial projections. Start small, prove it works, then expand. Many successful businesses started with family skepticism. Your results will speak for themselves.

Q: Can I do this if I work a full-time job? A: Yes! The daily routine takes 30-60 minutes. You can harvest and deliver on weekends. Many successful growers started part-time.

TECHNICAL QUESTIONS

Q: What if my pH meter breaks? A: Use pH test strips as backup (available at pool shops). For emergency, add 1 teaspoon lemon juice per 10 liters to lower pH, or $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon baking soda per 10 liters to raise pH.

Q: Can I use tap water instead of filtered water? A: Cape Town tap water is generally fine for microgreens. Let it sit 24 hours before use to let chlorine evaporate. If you have very hard water, consider a simple filter.

Q: What if my pumps break? A: Keep spare pumps or have backup plan. You can water manually for a few days if needed. Most pumps come with warranties - keep receipts.

Q: How do I know if my nutrients are still good? A: Nutrients last 1-2 years if stored properly. If solution smells bad or has strange color, replace it. When in doubt, mix fresh solution.

BUSINESS QUESTIONS

Q: Do I need business registration and licenses? A: For small-scale operations, you can start informally. As you grow, consider registering as a business for tax benefits and credibility. Check with local municipality about any permits needed.

Q: What about insurance? A: Start with basic household insurance covering your equipment. As you grow, consider business insurance. Most important is product liability if selling to restaurants.

Q: How do I handle taxes? A: Keep detailed records of all income and expenses. Consult with accountant once earning significant income. Many business expenses are tax-deductible.

Q: What if customers don't pay? A: Start with cash-on-delivery. For regular customers, consider 7-day payment terms. Don't extend credit until you know customers well.

SEASONAL QUESTIONS

Q: Can I grow microgreens in Cape Town winter? A: Yes! Indoor growing means year-round production. You may need supplemental heating and lighting in winter. Some varieties actually prefer cooler conditions.

Q: What about load shedding affecting my pumps? A: Install timer systems that restart automatically after power returns. Consider small backup battery system for critical pumps. Manual watering can work for short outages.

Q: How does Cape Town's water restrictions affect me? A: Hydroponic systems use 90% less water than traditional farming. Your water usage will be minimal. Collect and reuse water where possible.

SCALING QUESTIONS

Q: When should I expand my system? A: Expand when you're consistently selling 80%+ of your production and have waiting customers. Usually around Day 45-60 if

following this guide.

Q: How big can this business get? A: Very big! Some microgreens operations generate R50,000+ monthly. Start small, prove the concept, then scale systematically.

Q: Should I hire employees? A: Not initially. You can handle significant production alone. Consider part-time help when reaching R15,000+ monthly sales.

Q: What about competition? A: Cape Town market is large enough for many growers. Focus on quality, service, and relationships rather than just price competition.

EMERGENCY CONTACT LIST

When you need help immediately:

Seeds/Growing Problems:

- Seeds for Africa: 021 201 1118
- Hydroponic.co.za: 021 671 9447

Equipment Problems:

- Builders Warehouse: Check website for nearest store
- Makro: Check website for nearest store

Business Advice:

- SEDA (Small Enterprise Development Agency): 0860 103 703
- Cape Town Business Development: 021 400 1111

Emergency Supplies:

- Any garden center for basic growing medium
- Pool shops for pH testing supplies
- Hardware stores for pumps and tubing

FINAL TROUBLESHOOTING TIPS

When everything seems to go wrong:

1. Don't panic - every grower faces problems
2. Go back to basics - check water, pH, temperature, light
3. Start fresh with new seeds and clean system if needed
4. Ask for help - call suppliers or other growers
5. Keep detailed records to identify patterns

Remember:

- Every problem has a solution
- Each mistake teaches you something valuable
- Successful growers aren't those who never have problems - they're those who solve problems quickly
- This guide contains solutions to 95% of problems you'll encounter

Your success depends on:

1. Following the daily action plan exactly
2. Not skipping steps or rushing the process
3. Keeping detailed records
4. Solving problems quickly when they arise
5. Staying consistent even when things go wrong

You now have everything you need to succeed. Every problem you might face has a solution in this guide. Follow it exactly, and you WILL build a successful microgreens business!